

India's junior shuttlers shine with historic silver and bronze

The Indian contingent clinched a historic maiden team bronze, while Tanvi Sharma won silver, ending a **17-year wait** for a medal in the girls' singles event.

Nihit Sachdeva

nihit.s@thehindu.co.in

The National Centre of Excellence (NCE) in Guwahati has been home to the cream of India's next generation of badminton stars for over two years. Adding another feather to its cap, the venue hosted some of the most talented shuttlers from across the world during the BWF World Junior Championships, held from October 6-19.

Hosting the event for the first time since Pune 2008 played its part as the Indian contingent clinched a historic maiden team bronze. In the individual events, Junior World No. 1 Tanvi Sharma ended a 17-year wait for a medal in the girls' singles by winning silver.

Team bronze for the ages

The Badminton Association of India (BAI) selected 25 players from 13 states — one of its most diverse squads ever — following the World Junior Championships selection trials at the NCE in August.

The group then underwent a three-week preparatory camp under Korean Park Tae-seng (singles), Russian Ivan Sozonov (doubles) and Indian coaches.

With the likes of Tanvi and Unnati Hooda — both of whom have already shown tremendous potential at the senior level — a medal was always within reach in the mixed team event, called the Suhandinata

Cup, held from October 6-11.

The tournament introduced an updated relay scoring system, making matches more exciting. Each tie followed a best-of-three games format, with the first side to reach 45 points winning the game. A game comprised five matches — boys' singles, girls' singles, mixed doubles, boys' doubles and girls' doubles. Each match was played until one side scored nine points, after which the next began, continuing from the same cumulative score. The game concluded once a team reached the 45-point mark.

"We took feedback and suggested first-to-11 instead of nine points per match," said Sanjay Mishra, BAI General Secretary. "This is mainly being planned for the Sudirman Cup (the senior mixed team event held every two years). If the Sudirman Cup has 21 points (per game) and best-of-five matches, the tie goes on for six-seven hours. It's difficult for the audience to wait. To reduce the time, this is being planned. Maybe, it will be done in the next cycle."

Placed in Group H, India cruised into the knockout stage with 2-0 wins over Sri Lanka, the UAE and Nepal, while rotating six of its eight singles players and experimenting with different doubles pairings.

After conceding the opening game to Korea in the quarterfinals, Sozonov used the substitution rule to replace Viswa Tej Gobburu with C. Lalramsanga, who paired up with

Bhargav Ram Arigela in the boys' doubles. The move paid off, as the Bhargav-Lalramsanga duo gave the team winning starts in the next two games, making the job easier for the rest of the squad. India defeated Korea 44-45, 45-40, 45-33 to secure a semifinal spot and a medal. Unlike in 2008, there was no bronze-medal play-off.

Indonesia, however, ended India's dream run with a comprehensive 45-34, 45-21 win in the semifinal. China survived a scare to edge Japan 45-42, 38-45, 45-42 in the other one.

In the summit clash, China avenged last year's loss to Indonesia, winning 45-30, 45-44 to clinch a record-extending 15th title.

Tanvi breaks the singles barrier

After a day's rest, it was every player and pair for themselves as the individual leg got underway.

Even in this segment, a new scoring format was trialled as part of the Badminton World Federation's (BWF) broader testing and analysis programme. Each match followed a best-of-three format, with each game played to 15 points. If the score reached 14-all, a two-point lead was required to win a game. At 20-all, sudden death came into play.

Players accustomed to the conventional 21-points-per-game format had mixed views on the trial. While some felt it encouraged a more aggressive approach, others found that recovering from a slow start became more difficult. The early